# Low-Cost Edge-Based Adaptive Multi-Point Power Theft and Line-Fault Detection System with Feeder Segment Localization (Powerloss Sentinel)

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# ABSTRACT

Power distribution utilities suffer significant technical and commercial losses arising from both illegal power theft (non-technical loss) and genuine line faults (technical loss). Existing multi-point current comparison systems can detect a mismatch between two points on a feeder but cannot reliably distinguish its underlying cause, and typically use fixed or naively adaptive thresholds that risk absorbing an ongoing theft event into the learned baseline. This project presents a low-cost, edge-based system built on ESP32 microcontrollers and current-transformer (CT) sensors distributed along a feeder line. The system learns a normal current-loss baseline only during algorithmically-verified normal operating conditions, preventing baseline contamination by slow-onset anomalies. It classifies detected deviations into power theft, line fault, sensor failure, or communication failure using a combined feature set of mismatch magnitude, event duration, and waveform behaviour, and localizes the affected feeder segment via pairwise comparison across adjacent sensor nodes. Alerts are delivered in real time via SMS and/or a mobile application. The system was validated through a browser-based algorithmic simulation and a scaled laboratory feeder model, with performance measured in terms of detection time, classification accuracy, localization accuracy, and false alarm rate. The proposed design targets affordable, easily replicable hardware suitable for deployment by resource-constrained distribution utilities.

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# CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

## 1.1 Background

Aggregate technical and commercial (T&C) losses remain a persistent challenge for power distribution utilities worldwide, and are particularly severe in low- and middle-income regions. These losses arise from two distinct sources: non-technical losses caused by illegal tapping, meter bypass, or tampering, and technical losses caused by conductor faults, equipment degradation, or environmental damage. Utilities require a way to detect, classify, and localize such events quickly and cheaply to dispatch the correct response — enforcement for theft, repair crews for faults.

## 1.2 Problem Statement

Existing multi-point current comparison systems detect a mismatch in current between two points on a feeder line but suffer from three specific limitations: (1) fixed or naively adaptive thresholds that either produce excessive false alarms during normal load variation, or worse, gradually learn an ongoing theft event as the new normal; (2) an inability to distinguish the cause of a detected mismatch — theft, fault, sensor malfunction, or communication failure all present as the same generic alarm; and (3) no mechanism to localize the anomaly to a specific span of the feeder, forcing manual inspection of the entire line.

## 1.3 Objectives

1. To design a multi-point current sensing architecture using low-cost ESP32 microcontrollers and CT sensors.
2. To develop a contamination-gated adaptive threshold algorithm that learns the normal current-loss baseline only during verified normal conditions.
3. To design a multi-feature classification scheme distinguishing power theft, line fault, sensor failure, and communication failure.
4. To implement feeder segment localization based on pairwise adjacent-node current comparison.
5. To validate the system through simulation and a scaled laboratory prototype, measuring detection time, classification accuracy, localization accuracy, and false alarm rate.

## 1.4 Scope of the Project

This project covers the design, simulation, and laboratory-scale validation of the proposed detection and classification algorithm on a low-voltage test feeder. It does not cover deployment on a live medium- or high-voltage distribution network, which would require additional insulation, safety certification, and utility-grade communication infrastructure beyond the scope of an undergraduate project.

# CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE SURVEY

A number of prior works establish the foundation this project builds upon. Differential current sensing techniques compare supply-side and consumption-side current to flag unaccounted loss, forming the basis of most theft-detection systems. Multi-point extensions of this idea distribute current sensing across several nodes along a feeder rather than only at its two ends, improving spatial coverage. Separately, protection-relay literature addresses line-fault detection using abrupt current and voltage signatures, typically optimized for fast disconnection rather than classification or reporting. Adaptive-threshold approaches exist in load-monitoring literature, adjusting detection sensitivity to time-of-day or seasonal load patterns, but these generally lack an explicit safeguard against the threshold adapting to an anomalous condition itself.

[Expand this section with 8–12 papers from your own literature survey, each cited by author/year/journal, summarizing their method and explicitly noting the specific gap your project addresses relative to that paper.]

## 2.1 Summary of Identified Research Gaps

- No existing low-cost system prevents baseline contamination during a slow-onset theft event.
- Most systems provide binary alarm output rather than distinguishing theft from fault, sensor failure, or communication failure.
- Few systems localize the anomaly to a specific feeder segment rather than flagging the line as a whole.

# CHAPTER 3: SYSTEM ANALYSIS

## 3.1 Existing System

Conventional theft-detection deployments typically use two-point differential metering (at the transformer and at the consumer meter) with a fixed threshold. Line-protection systems separately monitor for fault conditions using dedicated relays. These systems operate independently, are costly to deploy at fine spatial granularity, and do not share information to jointly classify or localize events.

## 3.2 Proposed System

The proposed system distributes low-cost sensing nodes along the feeder, enabling segment-level comparison rather than only end-to-end comparison. A single edge-based algorithm handles adaptive learning, classification, and localization, removing the need for separate theft-detection and fault-protection subsystems for the purposes of monitoring and alerting.

**Table 1: Comparison of Existing and Proposed Systems**

| Capability | Existing Systems | Proposed System |
|---|---|---|
| Differential current comparison | Yes | Yes |
| Adaptive threshold | Fixed / naive adaptive | Contamination-gated adaptive |
| Event classification | Binary (alarm / no alarm) | 4-way: theft / fault / sensor fail / comms fail |
| Fault localization | Not supported | Segment-level localization |
| Cost basis | SCADA-grade / proprietary hardware | Low-cost ESP32 + CT sensors |

## 3.3 Feasibility Study

### *3.3.1 Technical Feasibility*

The system uses widely available, well-documented hardware (ESP32, SCT-013 CT sensors, SIM800L GSM module) and standard wireless protocols (Wi-Fi/ESP-NOW), making it feasible to prototype within a college laboratory setting.

### *3.3.2 Economic Feasibility*

Per-node hardware cost is significantly lower than SCADA-grade monitoring equipment, making dense deployment along a feeder economically viable for distribution utilities with constrained budgets.

### *3.3.3 Operational Feasibility*

The system requires minimal ongoing maintenance beyond periodic sensor calibration checks, and alerts integrate with existing SMS-based utility communication workflows.

# CHAPTER 4: SYSTEM DESIGN

## 4.1 System Architecture

The system consists of N current-sensing nodes positioned along a feeder, dividing it into N−1 segments. Each node samples current locally via a CT sensor and transmits readings to a central gateway. The gateway performs pairwise comparison between adjacent nodes, executes the classification algorithm, and dispatches alerts.

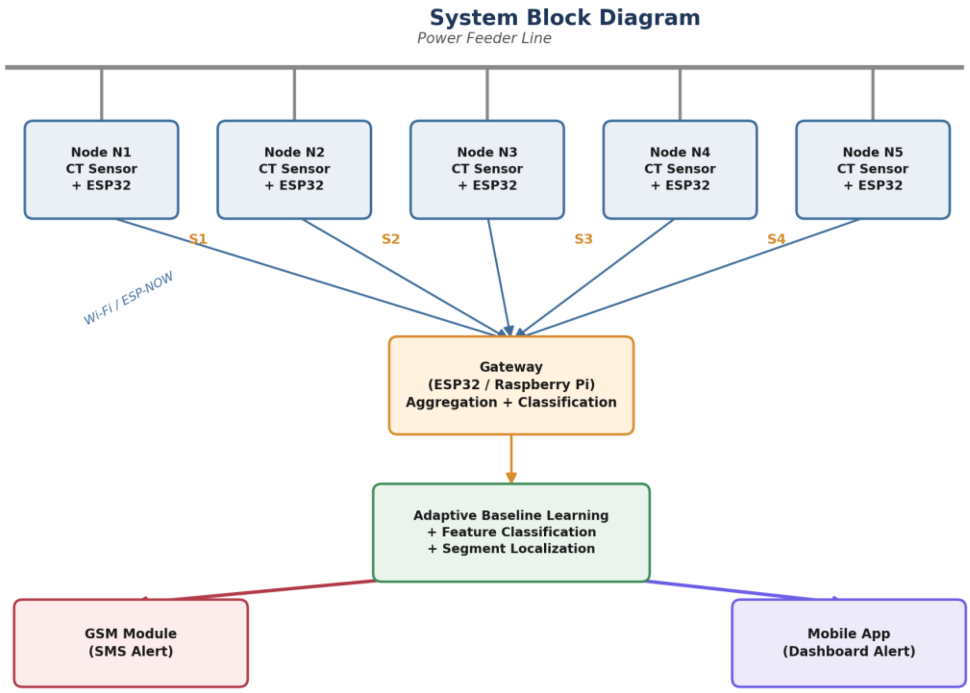


*Figure 1: System block diagram.*

## 4.2 Hardware Requirements

**Table 2: Hardware Components and Functions**

| Component | Function |
|---|---|
| ESP32 (per node) | Local current sampling and feature extraction |
| CT Sensor (SCT-013) | Non-invasive current sensing at each node |
| Gateway (ESP32 / Raspberry Pi) | Data aggregation, classification, alert dispatch |
| GSM Module (SIM800L) | SMS alert delivery to utility staff |
| Wi-Fi / ESP-NOW | Inter-node wireless communication |
| Lab feeder model | Scaled low-voltage test line with adjustable loads |
| Power supply unit | 5V/3.3V regulated supply for nodes |

## 4.3 Software Requirements

**Table 3: Software Tools and Purpose**

| Software / Tool | Purpose |
|---|---|
| Arduino IDE / PlatformIO | ESP32 firmware development |
| Embedded C / C++ | Sensing, feature extraction, communication logic |
| Python | Data logging, offline analysis, prototyping the classifier |
| MQTT / Firebase / Blynk | Cloud relay for mobile app alerts |
| Browser-based simulator | Algorithm validation before hardware deployment |

## 4.4 System Flowchart

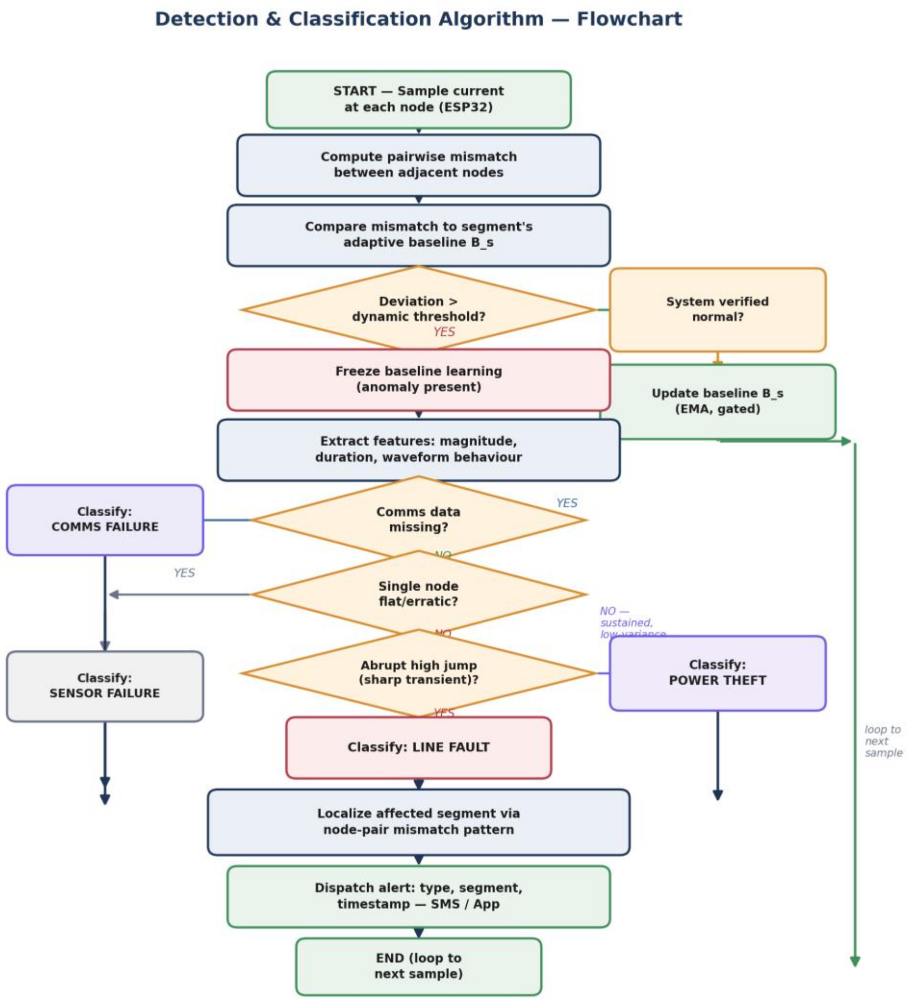


*Figure 2: Detection and classification algorithm flowchart.*

# CHAPTER 5: METHODOLOGY

## 5.1 Contamination-Gated Adaptive Baseline Learning

For each segment s, a rolling baseline B_s of expected current-loss is maintained using an exponential moving average. B_s is updated only when a verified-normal condition holds across the entire system at that instant, defined jointly by: (a) no segment currently flagging an active anomaly, (b) aggregate load within the expected diurnal envelope, and (c) no active sensor or communication fault flag. This gating condition is the central safeguard preventing a slow-onset theft event from being gradually absorbed into the learned baseline — a known failure mode of naive adaptive-threshold systems.

## 5.2 Multi-Feature Event Classification

When the live mismatch for a segment exceeds its baseline by more than a dynamic margin, three features are extracted:

- Deviation magnitude — how far the mismatch exceeds the learned baseline.
- Event duration/persistence — how many consecutive sampling cycles the deviation persists.
- Waveform behaviour — a proxy derived from the local rate of change and short-window variance of the mismatch signal.

A rule-based decision tree maps this feature vector to one of four categories, summarized in Table 4.

**Table 4: Classification Rules by Event Type**

| Event Type | Magnitude / Duration | Waveform Signature |
|---|---|---|
| Power Theft | Low–moderate, sustained | Low-variance, gradual onset |
| Line Fault | High, abrupt | Sharp transient, high jump |
| Sensor Failure | Flatline or erratic at one node | No correlation with load |
| Comms Failure | Missing data from a node | N/A — data absent |

## 5.3 Feeder Segment Localization

Because comparison is performed pairwise between adjacent nodes rather than only end-to-end, the specific node pair reporting an anomaly directly identifies the affected segment. If segment s alone reports an anomaly while its neighbouring segments remain normal, the event is localized to the physical span between the corresponding pair of nodes.

## 5.4 Alerting Mechanism

Once classified, the event type, segment identity, timestamp, and a confidence indicator are transmitted via SMS through a GSM module and, optionally, pushed to a mobile application dashboard for logging and trend analysis.

# CHAPTER 6: IMPLEMENTATION

## 6.1 Hardware Setup

[Describe your actual node placement, wiring, CT sensor calibration procedure, and lab feeder model construction here, once built.]

## 6.2 Firmware / Software Implementation

Each ESP32 node samples current at a fixed interval, computes a local RMS value, and transmits it to the gateway over Wi-Fi/ESP-NOW. The gateway runs the baseline-learning, classification, and localization logic described in Chapter 5, and triggers the GSM module upon a confirmed classification.

## 6.3 Algorithm Validation via Simulation

Prior to hardware deployment, the core algorithm was validated using a browser-based software simulation that models multiple sensor nodes, injects theft, fault, sensor-failure, and communication-failure scenarios, and verifies that the classifier correctly labels each event without being given the ground truth in advance. This simulation was used to tune the gating condition, deviation margins, and waveform-based decision rules before implementing them on the ESP32 firmware.

# CHAPTER 7: RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

The system was evaluated across repeated trials of each of the four event types, on both the software simulation and the laboratory prototype. Table 5 presents the classification confusion matrix and Table 6 summarizes the aggregate detection metrics.

**Table 5: Classification Confusion Matrix (populate from test trials)**

| Actual \ Predicted | Theft | Fault | Sensor Fail | Comms Fail |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Theft | [x] | [x] | [x] | [x] |
| Fault | [x] | [x] | [x] | [x] |
| Sensor Fail | [x] | [x] | [x] | [x] |
| Comms Fail | [x] | [x] | [x] | [x] |

**Table 6: Aggregate Performance Metrics (populate from test trials)**

| Metric | Result |
|---|---|
| Average detection time | [x] seconds |
| Classification accuracy | [x] % |
| Segment localization accuracy | [x] % |
| False alarm rate (normal load variation) | [x] % |
| Baseline convergence time | [x] minutes |
| Alert delivery latency (SMS) | [x] seconds |

*Figure 4: Representative segment mismatch trace against the adaptively-learned baseline threshold.*

# CHAPTER 8: CONCLUSION AND FUTURE SCOPE

## 8.1 Conclusion

This project presented a low-cost, edge-deployable system that combines contamination-gated adaptive baseline learning with multi-feature event classification and feeder segment localization. It addresses three specific limitations of conventional multi-point current comparison systems: susceptibility to baseline contamination, inability to distinguish event causes, and lack of spatial localization. The system was validated through algorithmic simulation and a laboratory-scale prototype, demonstrating its feasibility for low-cost distribution-level deployment.

## 8.2 Future Scope

- Replacing the rule-based classifier with a lightweight trained model (e.g., a compact decision tree or quantized neural network) for improved accuracy on ambiguous events.
- Extending the testbed to a larger number of segments and real feeder lengths.
- Integrating solar-powered nodes for remote, off-grid deployment.
- Conducting field trials on an operational low-voltage distribution feeder in partnership with a utility.
- Filing a patent application covering the contamination-gated learning and combined classification mechanism.

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